UK data and analytics consultancies: who is being set up, and who is really trading

Ananya Rajawat · MSc Business Analytics and Management, University of Southampton · November 2026

Data: Companies House Free Company Data Product, snapshot of 1 November 2026 (live companies only).

The question

How many UK data and analytics consultancies have been set up recently, where are they registered, and how many of a random sample show a verifiable working business?

What I found

1. Firm formation rose about threefold between 2019 and 2025. After removing shared-address registrations, surviving matching firms went from 331 incorporated in 2019 to 992 in 2025, and 1,056 in 2026 up to 1 November.

2. Shared addresses inflate the raw counts. Of 6,060 initial matches, 1,377 (22.7%) were registered at postcodes shared by ten or more matching firms. That share rose from about 14% of 2019 firms to about 32% of 2026 firms. I describe the pattern but do not explain it. Removing them changes the 2026 picture most: the raw count was 1,555, the cleaned count 1,056.

3. London accounts for about one in five matching firms. 923 of 4,683 (19.7%) are registered in London, followed by Manchester (102), Birmingham (68), Leeds, Edinburgh and Bristol (55 each). This is the registered address, not where people work.

4. In a random sample of 60 firms, 19 (32%) showed a verifiable working data or analytics business, and 17 of those were independent small firms.

Area	Sampled	Met all four criteria	Share
London	30	14	47%
Rest of UK	30	5	17%
All	60	19	32%

With 30 firms per group, the 95% ranges (roughly 30 to 64% and 7 to 34%) overlap, so I do not claim London firms are more likely to be genuine.

How I did it

I loaded 5,711,779 company records into SQLite and kept active private limited companies incorporated from 2019 with relevant SIC codes and name keywords (6,060 firms). I excluded postcodes shared by ten or more of these firms (leaving 4,683); thresholds of 5, 10 and 20 would have removed 1,560, 1,377 and 1,233 firms, so the size of the exclusion is not sensitive to the cutoff. From a pool of 1,395 firms incorporated 2019 to 2024, I drew one random sample of 30 London and 30 rest-of-UK firms.

Each sampled firm was checked by hand against four criteria fixed in advance: a website belonging to that company (checked against the registered number), a description of data or analytics services, two or more named people, and a sign of recent activity. Firms that passed were then classed as independent small firms or subsidiaries of larger groups.

So what

- **Company registrations overstate the market.** Before any check for real activity, roughly a fifth of matching firms sat at shared addresses.
- **Registration is a weak proxy for trading.** In the sample, only about a third of firms passed all four checks, so market-size estimates built on registrations alone should be treated with caution.
- **A better measure combines the register with a verification step.** Even a light one (a website that matches the registered number, a described service, a visible team) separates working firms from shells far better than SIC codes alone.

Limitations

- **Survivorship bias:** the snapshot holds live companies only, so dissolved firms are invisible and recent years look stronger than older ones.
- **SIC codes are self-reported,** and the name-keyword filter misses firms with other names while matching some unrelated businesses.
- **Shared-address rule:** the threshold of ten is a judgement, and some genuine startups use virtual offices.
- **The screening pool covers 2019 to 2024.** Firms from 2025 and 2026 were left out because very new companies have little web presence.
- **Small sample, one reviewer:** 60 firms, screened and classed by one person, with judgement involved in "appears active" and in the firm types.
- **Registered town is not where people work,** and "Rest of UK" includes outer-London towns.

Method, SQL and results are on GitHub: [repository link].